NxtGen Kids Church App — What We're Building

Oct 14, 2026 · @Roy

Overview

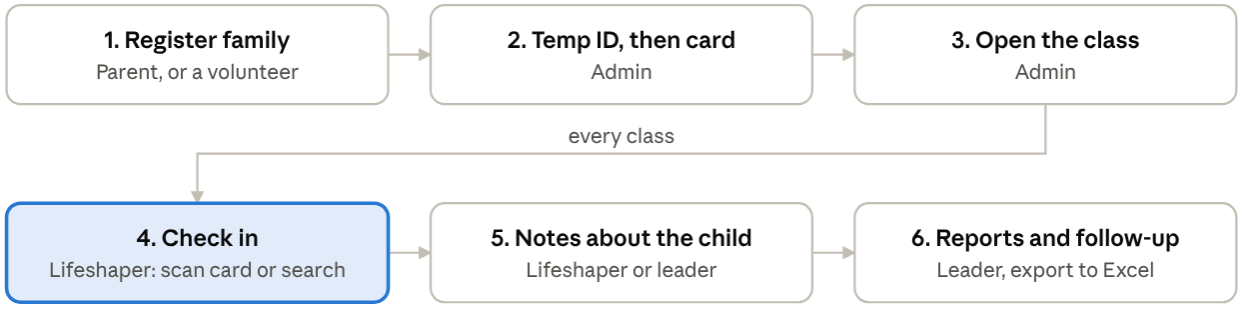
This is one app for running a kids church. Parents sign up their kids. Volunteers check kids in and send them home safely. Leaders keep all the records in one place. No more paper lists.

We are building it first for **NxtGen**, the kids church of **CCF DXB**. But it is not made only for us. Any church can use it. We already built a test version and tried it. The real one is due by 28 October 2026.

Who uses it

Who	What they do	On what
Parent	Signs up the family and kids, and asks for ID cards. Logs in with an email link (no password)	Their phone
Lifeshaper (volunteer)	Checks kids in (scan the card or search the name), registers families when parents can't, writes notes	Their phone
Admin (leader)	Looks after families, kids, classes, ID cards and volunteers	A laptop

A child goes from sign-up to follow-up in six steps



a child's journey · 6 steps

Steps 1 and 2 happen once per child. Steps 3 to 6 repeat at every class.

When

Registration comes first, so families can start registering soon. Check-in follows by the end of October.

1. Churches and satellites

Each church gets its own private space in the app. Think of it as its own locked room. CCF is the first one.

A church can have several **satellites** (places where it meets), like CCF DXB or a House Church. Each satellite sets up its own classes.

- A family belongs to **the whole church**, and attends **one satellite**, for example Holy Trinity Church. Their kids keep the same details and the same ID card wherever they go.
- At any satellite's door, a volunteer can **find any child in the church**, so a child visiting from another satellite is checked in, not signed up twice. For a visiting child the volunteer sees only the basics: name, nickname, allergies and group.
- Volunteers and leaders manage only their own satellite, unless they have a higher role (see Admin tools).
- A volunteer can serve in more than one satellite.
- People only see their own church. One church never sees another church's kids.
- We can add a new church without building a new app.
- Each church gets its own sign-up link and QR code for parents.
- **Later:** a child could visit a *different* church in the app without signing up again.

2. Family and child registration

Parents sign up once, as a family, with one family email. Then they add each of their kids. A leader can also do this for them.

How it works

1. The parent scans the church's QR code, or opens its link.
2. They fill in the family details and the family email.
3. They add each child.
4. If the family looks already signed up, the app warns them, so nobody is added twice.
5. Each new child gets a **temporary ID** card straight away, with their name written on it, so they can check in that same day. Their status is **pending** until their real ID card is printed.

6. The app sends the family an email with a link to log in.

Registering at church (by a volunteer). Every child must be registered before they can check in. It is always best for parents to register on their own phone. If a parent has no internet, a volunteer or leader can register for them on the volunteer's phone:

1. **Search first.** The volunteer looks up the parent's name, phone or the child's name. The app shows close matches ("Is this the Ramos family?"), so nobody is registered twice.
2. **Family found:** add the child to that family. **Not found:** register the family and the child.
3. **An email is required.** The app sends a "please confirm your email" link to it. Until the parent taps it, the family shows **email not confirmed**.
4. **The child can still check in straight away.** An unconfirmed email never blocks the door.
5. **Next visit:** the volunteer sees the "email not confirmed" badge and can send the link again, or fix the email if it was typed wrong.

Where the family lives. For now, parents type their area (for example "Al Barsha"). Later, they will pick it on a map, which keeps area names the same for everyone and helps leaders find a DGroup nearby.

What we collect

About the family	About each parent (dad and mum)	About each child
Email	First and last name	First and last name, nickname
Area where they live (typed for now)	Phone number	Boy or girl
Facebook account	Which ministries they serve in	Birthday (the app works out the age)
Join the parents' FB group or chat? (yes/no)		Allergies
In a DGroup? Which area? Who is the leader?		Sickness or illness
Want to join a DGroup? (yes/no)		What they don't like, what scares them
Satellite they attend (e.g. Holy Trinity Church) and usual class		Notes from parents, and a photo (only if the parent agrees)

We show the child's nickname everywhere, because that is what kids are called. Allergies show as a bright warning, so no volunteer can miss them. Health details (allergies, illness, fears) can only be seen by Lifeshapers and the child's own parents.

Logging in without a password. Parents never make a password. They type the family email, and the app emails them a link. Tapping the link logs them in.

Forgot which email? This happens a lot. A volunteer can search for the child and tell the parent which email the family used. A leader can change the family email if needed.

Signed up twice? Sometimes a parent signs up the same child again. A leader can **join the two records into one**. Everything (attendance, notes, cards) moves to the record we keep, and the app notes who joined them and when.

Child status. Each child is one of:

- **Active**: comes to NxtGen now.
- **Inactive**: stopped coming (for example, moved away). They can come back any time.
- **Graduated**: finished NxtGen and moved up to Elevate (teens).

Only active kids show on the check-in list. Inactive and graduated kids are kept for history.

Today's data. We will bring in the kids from today's Google Sheet, so families don't have to register again.

What parents can do after logging in. First, the must-haves:

- Sign up the family.
- Add their kids.
- Look after their kids' ID cards, like asking for a new one.

Later, after the must-haves:

- See which classes their kids came to.
- Read the notes volunteers wrote about their kids.
- Leave their own notes for the volunteers.

3. Classes and check-in

Each satellite sets up its own **classes**. A class has a name the church picks, like "1PM", "7PM" or "House Church", and can repeat every week. A child can go to any class, any week. The app records which satellite and which class the child came to each time.

Events

- A leader sets up the classes once. Weekly classes then repeat by themselves.
- A leader can also add one-time events, like a camp or a special day.

- A leader opens the class so volunteers can check kids in, and closes it when it ends.

Groups. Kids are put in groups by **age and gender**, for example "Level 2 Boys". Each church sets up its own groups.

Moving up. A child does not change group by themselves when they have a birthday. Groups only change at **Moving-Up**, a yearly event the leaders hold.

- The app shows a **"ready to move up"** sign on each child who has grown past their group's age.
- Before Moving-Up, a leader sees the list of these kids and decides who moves.
- The leader confirms, and the chosen kids move to their new group together. Kids leaving the oldest group are marked **graduated** (on to Elevate).
- The final decision is always the leader's. The app only suggests.

Check-in at the door

- The volunteer sees the list of all kids on their phone.
- To find a child, they **scan the child's ID card** with the phone camera, or **type the name**. Today's barcode cards work.
- The search finds nicknames and spelling mistakes too. Typing "Kaern" still finds Karen.
- One tap checks a child in. Brothers and sisters can be checked in together.
- Tapped the wrong child? Undo it.
- Volunteers can filter the list by group, and by who is in or not yet in.

Later: works with no signal. The first release needs internet. After it, we do one "speed and offline" round: make the app send less data so it loads fast on weak signal, then let check-in keep working with no signal and send everything when the signal comes back. The first release is built so this can be added without starting over.

Later: kids check themselves in. A tablet on a stand with a small scanner (about AED 1,600 each, or about AED 820 if we use a tablet we already have). The child holds their card under the scanner, it beeps, and they are checked in. It works without internet too. No CCTV needed.

4. Notes, and what comes after check-in

Notes. A volunteer or leader can add a short note to a child, like how they behaved or something to watch. Every note shows who wrote it and when. Notes stay on the child's page, so leaders can see how the child is growing. Notes can also be added to other things, like a request for a new ID card.

Later (not in the first release):

- **Squad Leader notes to parents.** A Squad Leader writes a note to one specific parent. Squad Leaders log in too.
- **Roll call and head count** during class, to check every child who checked in is in the room.
- **Going home.** The parent or guardian taps the child's ID card. Parents keep their own list of people allowed to pick up. If the adult is not on the list, the child waits.

5. ID cards

Every child has an ID card. A volunteer scans it to find the child fast. **For now we keep today's barcode cards.** No new cards will be printed until after Moving-Up in February. Then all cards are reprinted with a **QR code** (the square black-and-white code).

Why QR after February:

- Faster: phones read a QR code from any angle, even when the card is tilted.
- Still works if scratched or partly covered.
- A lost card can be switched off. Today's barcode is just the child's name, so a lost card works forever.
- No personal details inside the code, only a random code for that card.
- It takes about the same space as today's barcode (about 2 cm square). The nickname stays big.

Printing cards in our design. The app makes a printable sheet of cards in the NxtGen design: the nickname in big letters, the full name under it, and the code. A leader prints it from the browser. We will print a test sheet first to pick the smallest QR size that scans quickly.

New kids. When a parent signs up a child, the child gets a **temporary ID card with their name written on it**, and shows as **pending**. When the real card is printed and handed over, the child is no longer pending.

Asking for a new card (lost or broken)

1. A parent or a volunteer asks for a new card in the app. With the new QR cards, a lost card stops working right away, so nobody else can use it. (Today's barcode cards can't be switched off.) Until February, new cards are recorded but not printed.
2. **The first card is free. A replacement costs AED 10.** The app shows the cost and tracks if it has been paid.
3. A leader checks the request and says yes.
4. The new card goes on the print list.
5. The leader prints the card and marks it done. The new card works from then on.

Each request shows who asked, when, and its notes, so everyone can see where it is.

Forgot your card? The child borrows a spare card for the day. The app remembers who has it until it comes back.

6. Admin tools

Leaders can do everything a volunteer can. Each leader gets the dashboard, but only sees what their level allows:

- **Church admin:** everything in the church, all satellites.
- **Satellite admin:** only their satellite (for example Holy Trinity Church): its classes, kids, families, attendance and volunteers.
- **Class admin:** only their class (for example 1PM).

A person can have more than one, for example admin of both the 1PM and 7PM classes. Joining duplicate records is for church admins.

What leaders can do, within their level:

Area	What a leader can do
Volunteers	Add them, choose which satellites they serve in, make them a volunteer or a leader, turn off their account, reset their password
Families	See, add and change families and parents. Change the family email when a parent forgets it
Kids	See, add and change kids. Set a child as active, inactive or graduated. Join duplicate records into one
Events	Set up each satellite's classes (any name, like 1PM or House Church), weekly or one-time. Open and close them
Attendance	See who came to each class, each child's history, families to follow up, and kids due to move up. Fix mistakes. Every list can be downloaded to Excel
ID cards	Check new-card requests, mark them paid, print new cards, mark them done

Everyone's screen updates by itself. When one volunteer checks a child in, the others see it straight away, without reloading.

7. Not in this first release

- Stars and rewards. Kids love having a volunteer stamp their card, so we keep that instead (agreed with Kuya Adam)
- Working with no signal, and making the app faster on weak signal
- Picking the area on a map (typed for now)
- Kids checking themselves in at a kiosk
- Roll call and head count during class
- Going home / pickup by tapping the child's card
- Squad Leader notes to parents, and parents seeing attendance and notes
- The Moving-Up button, and new QR cards and printing (all ready for Moving-Up in February). The "ready to move up" sign and list come in the first release
- Volunteer schedules (who serves when)
- Visiting another church without registering again
- A live link to Google Sheets (every list can be downloaded to Excel instead)
- Text or WhatsApp messages to parents

Questions for stakeholders

- [ ] What is the AED 5 for, and how will the two tablets be set up? (to discuss in the meeting)
- [ ] Today's printed cards: is the barcode the nickname + surname, or the full name? The app can read both, and we will test real cards.
- [ ] Is there a record of who came to past classes (not just head counts)? If yes, we can bring it in.
- [ ] Should we buy a kiosk tablet and scanner now, or wait until the QR cards in February?